

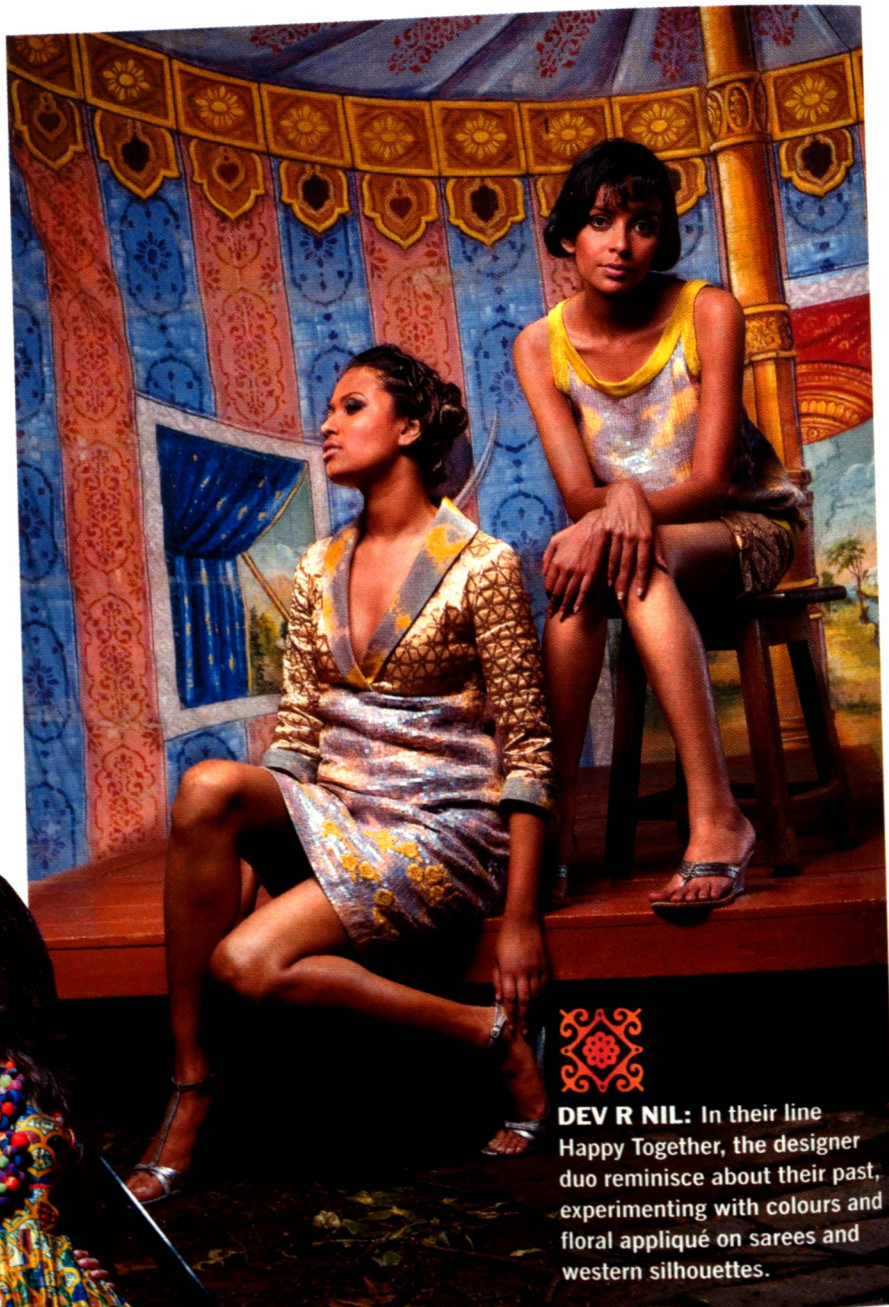
the Indian essence. Even as Agnimitra Paul revives kantha embroidery and showcases it on sarees and tunics and designer duo Dev r Nil spell their magic on the six-yard wonder, also expect to see the saree waft down the catwalks of Puri and Dayal.

With a collection titled India Inspires, Shyamal Shodhan proclaims it to be his most satisfying fashion week range ever. "Our last two collections have been very western. Today, the world is looking at India for inspiration. So why shouldn't we embrace what is ours?" says Shodhan of his 1820s-grandeur-meets-India-of-the-2020s line. While Tawadey's Wandering Minstrels tweaks the Indian silhouette with racer-back kalidar kurtas, backless angarkhas and Kutch-inspired jamdani bomber jackets, Dayal, whose USP is her "un-embarrassed Indian look" attempts to "take bits and pieces of our heritage and modernise it in a multi-ethnic-meets-techno look" in her collection The Oracle.

On eastern shores, Dev r Nil experiment with floral appliqué and tie-and-dye in their romance-infused collection Happy Together. Says Dev, "As the industry matures we must realise that if we do things our way and show the world what we are good at, they will naturally like it. Right now you can't go wrong with anything inspired by India."

The back-to-nature theme, heralded at the Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week, plays on in Mumbai with Ekta Jaipuria and Ruchira

NIKASHA: Her line Wandering Minstrels is inspired by the Baul singers of Bengal. Jamdanis meet gold lurex and Kutch-inspired bomber jackets meet the humble dhoti.



DEV R NIL: In their line Happy Together, the designer duo reminisce about their past, experimenting with colours and floral appliqué on sarees and western silhouettes.

Khandari of Ekru rolling out an eco-friendly collection called The Sapling, where organic cotton is used in a retro feminine play of gathers, ruffles and trimmings. Gayatri Khanna has taken a more obvious approach with her line Our Beautiful Earth—Prevent Global Warming, where elements like forest fires and lava bursts have inspired some unique prints.

And even as designers look like they are ready to

embrace their roots with their India-inspired lines, the domestic buyers tally at LFW has also gone up. Their "global integration" mantra notwithstanding, Anil Chopra, vice-president, Lakme Lever, admits that despite the clamour for international attention, the local buyer is becoming a significant constituent. "It is important in every business to be strong on the home-front. Designers are also realising that they cannot hanker after international acclaim at the cost of the domestic market. With his Indian couture show, and international prêt show even Sabyasachi has realised that both markets are equally